

A Virginia Win
As Democrats
Bare Knuckles

Party Embraces Tactics
It Once Opposed

By **KELLEN BROWNING**

Democrats' success in pushing through one of the country's most aggressively gerrymandered congressional maps on Tuesday in Virginia represented the latest example of the party's willingness to take the gloves off as it seeks to win back control of Congress and thwart President Trump's agenda. It was a stark reversal for a party that has decried partisan gerrymandering for years. But Democrats said that the new map, which could flip as many as four Republican-held seats, was necessary to counter similar G.O.P. efforts in Texas and other states. Their new mantra: It's time to play hardball. "While many expected Democrats to roll over and play dead, we did the opposite," Hakeem Jeffries, the House Democratic leader from New York, said in a statement after The Associated Press called the race. "Democrats did not step back. We fought back. When they go low, we hit back hard."

The party's newly combative approach extends beyond redistricting as it has felt a new urgency to regain power in Washington. Despite their qualms over dark money, Democrats are nowadays more reliant on it than Republicans. And on Capitol Hill, they have adopted an uncompromising approach to spending negotiations, forcing a partial government shutdown earlier this year after they refused to fund immigration enforcement operations without new restrictions on federal agents' tactics. It all amounts to a new openness among Democrats — spurred on by constituents demanding more forceful opposition to Mr. Trump — to reverse their opposition to political tactics they once considered bad governance. None have been more head-spinning than the Virginia gerrymander, which transforms a nearly evenly divided 11-member congressional delegation into one with only one sure Republican seat. Proponents framed the initiative as a less than ideal but necessary rebuttal to a gerrymandering war started by Republicans. The

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SLICED Both parties are splitting urban areas to eke out a partisan advantage. The julienned districts have little in common. **PAGE A14**

Influencers, Rebuffing Doctors,
Push a 'Natural' Elixir: Nicotine

By **DANI BLUM**

There's a compound that can reverse Alzheimer's, increase cognitive function and potentially even help you live longer, Dave Asprey, a biohacking influencer, has told his million-plus social media followers. The wonder drug? Nicotine. Mr. Asprey claims.

Lanna Apisukh for The New York Times

Nicotine pouches are among the products being promoted.

A new wave of health influencers like Mr. Asprey, many of whom are aligned with the Make America Healthy Again movement, is championing nicotine as a health product. They promote nicotine patches, gums and lozenges as well as pouches, which are often filled with nicotine salt powder and give people a convenient way to consume the compound. To these boosters, nicotine is another "natural" product that the medical establishment has unfairly demonized, like beef tallow, peptides or raw milk. Jillian Michaels, a celebrity fitness trainer, has spoken about the health benefits of nicotine on her podcast. She said in an interview that she uses low doses of nicotine to protect against Parkinson's disease and Alzheimer's and sharpen her focus, which she said is affected by A.D.H.D. "Nicotine, unto itself, is not

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KIANA HAYERI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Leaving Home, and Loved Ones, as Iran's Economy Falters
At Turkey's Kapikoy crossing on Wednesday, Iranian parents said goodbye to a family that had received a work visa for Australia.

Hospice Fraud
Is a Flashpoint
For California

By **SOUMYA KARLAMANGLA**

SAN FRANCISCO — Hospice fraud in California has been remarkably brazen. Medicare recipients have been signed up for care without their knowledge by thieves who stole their identities. Providers have paid kickbacks to people to enroll even though they aren't terminally ill and don't qualify. Sham companies have fabricated lists of employees. The schemes have been an irresistible political target for President Trump, who mentioned California as a top offender when he created a task force last month to root out corruption in federally funded programs. He said that he believed that fraud in the nation's most populous state was "10 times worse" than anywhere else. But long before Mr. Trump weighed in, state investigators had uncovered rampant fraud in California's hospice system on their own. For years, state and federal officials had been taking steps to combat abuses, and the state has

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Long Year of Struggle for Fired U.S.A.I.D. Staff

By **ELISABETH BUMILLER** and **EILEEN SULLIVAN**

WASHINGTON — She was fired by email while on maternity leave, given 24 hours to clear out her desk and left with three days of health insurance and no severance pay. She had worked for the U.S. Agency for International Development or related groups for more than two decades. She made \$175,000 a year. That was Jan. 28, 2025. Today Amy Uccello and her husband, who also lost his job when U.S.A.I.D. funding for his nonprofit dried up, rely on food stamps, Medicaid and a supplemental nutrition program for women and children that helps with their now 19-month-old daughter. The mortgage on their home in Washington was until recently in forbearance, meaning they negotiated to pay less than they owed each month. But the bank has now cut them off and suggested they apply for a low-income mortgage program. "We don't know if we'll qualify," Ms. Uccello said. She and her husband have applied for more than 100 jobs with no luck. Most of their friends don't have jobs either. Nights are the hardest. "I can't sleep because of our own situation," Ms. Uccello, 49, said over coffee on a recent afternoon. "I can't sleep because of what I know what's happening around the world. I can't sleep because my former colleagues and friends are also suffering." When the Trump administration dismantled the sprawling global aid agency last year, it wiped out virtually an entire industry — international development — that had been based in Washington since U.S.A.I.D.'s creation. *Continued on Page A18*



PHOTOGRAPHS BY SALWAN GEORGES FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Jacqueline Devine, 66, who used to work in sub-Saharan Africa on H.I.V. treatment, now relies on a \$9,000 income from teaching.



WHO BLINKED? Iran's leaders believe that they can withstand an enduring standoff longer than President Trump. **PAGE A9**

CUT OFF The United States has halted dollar shipments to Iraq's cash-based economy. **PAGE A8**

Clashes Over Civil Rights Group's 'Hate' Labels Preceded Charges

By **RICHARD FAUSSET**

For much of the 21st century, the Southern Poverty Law Center has been at the center of a bitter partisan war in America over what constitutes hate. The law center, which is based in Alabama, began in 1971, earning a reputation for battling the Ku Klux Klan in court and helping reporters and law enforcement keep tabs on far-right domestic extremists. More recently, however, the S.R.L.C. has earned the ire of conservatives by criticizing a number of organizations — including Moms For Liberty, the Family Research Council and Turning Point USA — that many on the right consider to be squarely within the American mainstream. The conflict entered a new phase this week, when the Justice Department charged the S.P.L.C. with a number of financial crimes, including wire fraud and conspiracy to commit money laundering. The indictment focused on the law center's past use of paid informants to infiltrate far-right groups. Todd Blanche, the acting attorney general, accused the group of "manufacturing racism to justify its existence." To some who have been criticized by the S.P.L.C., it was a moment to savor — a potential comeuppance for what they perceive to

IRAN ANNOUNCES
IT SEIZED 2 SHIPS
NEAR THE STRAIT

THAT'S 'OUR RED LINE'

Still No Plan for Talks —
Rivals Vie for Control
of Key Waterway

This article is by **Lynsee Chutel, Leo Sands and Michael Levenson**.

Iran's Islamic Revolutionary Guards Corps said on Wednesday it had seized two cargo ships near the Strait of Hormuz, as Tehran asserted control over the strategic waterway a day after President Trump extended a cease-fire with Iran but maintained a blockade on the country's ports. Both ships came under fire before they were seized, according to the United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations, a naval agency. One of them, the Epaminondas, had been transiting the strait about 23 miles off the coast of Oman when a crewed gunboat approached and fired on it about 6:50 a.m. local time, according to Technomar Shipping, a Greek company that manages the Liberian-flagged ship. The crew members were "safe and accounted for," and there were no reports of injuries, the company said. Greece's foreign minister, Giorgos Gerapetritis, told CNN that the ship had "extremely wide damage." MSC, a global shipping company that owns the other seized ship, the MSC Francesca, did not respond to a request for comment on that vessel, which was flying a Panamanian flag and bound for Sri Lanka. The Revolutionary Guards' Navy said the MSC Francesca and the Epaminondas had tried to pass through the strait "without the necessary permits" and were being directed toward Iran's coast. "Disrupting the order and security of the Strait of Hormuz is our red line," the Guards said in a statement carried by the semiofficial Tasnim news agency. Location data from the MSC Francesca and the Epaminondas, transmitted on Wednesday afternoon, suggested they were anchored about eight miles off the Iranian coast, said Daniel Mueller, a senior analyst at the maritime intelligence firm Ambrey, which could indicate that they were under Iranian control. He said the ships had been intercepted leaving the strait, suggesting that the Iranian authorities had allowed them to enter, most likely the night before. The seizures reflected rising naval tensions between the United States and Iran, amid uncertainty over diplomatic talks attempting to find an end to the war. On Wednesday, Karoline Leav- *Continued on Page A10*

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CUT OFF The United States has halted dollar shipments to Iraq's cash-based economy. **PAGE A8**

NATIONAL A12-21

F.B.I. Inquiry Into Writer

The agency is said to have investigated a New York Times reporter after she wrote about the girlfriend of the bureau's director, Kash Patel. **PAGE A20**

Lifeline for Renewable Energy

A judge halted the Trump administration's efforts to throttle wind and solar projects across the country. **PAGE A16**

OBITUARIES B10-11

From Bodybuilder to Artist

Paul Waldman turned from muscles to making subversive paintings and an art museum for birds. He was 89. **PAGE B10**

INTERNATIONAL A4-11

Afghans May Head to Africa

President Trump is said to be in talks to send to Congo a group of Afghans who helped U.S. forces in the war. **PAGE A11**

For Prisoners, a Welcome Hand

Sugey Amaya, whose brother is jailed in El Salvador, helps inmates who are given a chance to go free. **PAGE A6**



BUSINESS B1-5

Trying to Shed 'Puppet' Label

Kevin Warsh, at his confirmation hearing to lead the Fed, sought to dispel doubts he would yield to President Trump's demand for lower rates. **PAGE B1**

Mars or the Moon or A.I.?

As SpaceX readies an I.P.O., Elon Musk has proposed different goals from the original aim of reaching Mars. **PAGE B1**

THURSDAY STYLES D1-6

Two Brothers, Many Feuds

For years, Prajit and Projjal Dutta have led the market for South Asian art in the U.S. Now, they are at odds. **PAGE D4**

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Listening to Both Sides

At twice-monthly gatherings in Brooklyn, people listen to entire albums, the old-fashioned way, on vinyl. **PAGE C1**

Playing the Part So Well

Krysten Ritter dons the black leather jacket again as the character Jessica Jones in a "Daredevil" series. **PAGE C1**



SPORTS B6-9, 12

N.F.L. Scouts' High-Tech Tools

To prepare for the draft, teams once relied on VCRs. Now they can sort mountains of data instantly. **PAGE B6**

Rocky, and Muddy, Ski Season

Little snow and warm weather forced some resorts to close early, but die-hards kept the party going. **PAGE B7**

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Jill Filipovic

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